

16 Isaac

The long-awaited son of promise, laid on the altar and given back, who carried God's covenant quietly for a lifetime.

Isaac was the son Abraham and Sarah waited twenty-five years to hold, and his name echoes their laughter. On Mount Moriah he was bound on the altar, until God stopped Abraham's hand and provided a ram. His own story is quieter than his father's or his son's. He married Rebekah, prayed for her when she was barren, dug wells, and chose peace with his neighbors. He also repeated his father's lie and favored one son, which split his family. Yet God called himself "the God of Isaac," and the promise passed through him intact.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yitschaq</i> , "he laughs"
Family	Son of Abraham and Sarah; husband of Rebekah; father of twins
When	Traditionally c. 2066–1886 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Beersheba, Moriah, Beer-lahai-roi, Gerar, Hebron
Key people	Abraham, Sarah, Rebekah, Esau, Jacob, Abimelech
Lifespan	180 years (Genesis 35:28)
Main passages	Genesis 21–22; 24:62–67; 25:19–28:5; 35:27–29
New Testament	Romans 9:7–10; Galatians 4:28; Hebrews 11:17–20

"I am the God of Abraham thy father: fear not, for I am with thee, and will bless thee, and multiply thy seed for my servant Abraham's sake."

Genesis 26:24, KJV

The life of Isaac

Ages come from *Genesis*. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Isaac born c. 2066 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Birth	● The promised son Sarah bears Isaac when Abraham is a hundred; at his weaning Abraham holds a great feast. <i>Genesis 21:1–8</i>
On Moriah	● Laid on the altar Isaac asks, "Where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" The angel of the LORD stops Abraham, and a ram is offered. <i>Genesis 22:1–14</i>
Age 40	● Marries Rebekah Meditating in the field at evening, Isaac meets her, loves her, and is comforted after his mother's death. <i>Genesis 24:62–67; 25:20</i>
Age 60	● Father of twins After twenty barren years, Isaac prays, and Rebekah bears Esau and Jacob. <i>Genesis 25:20–26</i>
Age 75	● Buries Abraham Isaac and Ishmael bury their father at Machpelah, and God blesses Isaac. <i>Genesis 25:7–11</i>
In Gerar	● Blessed in famine God renews Abraham's promises. Isaac reaps a hundredfold, reopens wells and makes peace with Abimelech. <i>Genesis 26:1–33</i>
Old and blind	● Blesses Jacob Deceived by Rebekah and Jacob, he trembles at the truth, yet confirms the blessing. <i>Genesis 27:1–28:5</i>
Age 180	● Dies Isaac dies "old and full of days," and Esau and Jacob bury him together. <i>Genesis 35:27–29</i>

Key activities

Genesis does not give Isaac's age on Moriah. He is called "the lad" and is strong enough to carry the wood. Jewish tradition later made him a grown man who went willingly. The text itself stays silent about what he felt.

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- I Carried the wood.** He climbed the mountain with his father, carrying the wood for his own sacrifice. *Genesis 22:6-8*

 - 2 Was bound on the altar.** He was laid on the wood, and God provided a ram in his place. *Genesis 22:9-13*

 - 3 Received a wife by prayer.** Abraham's servant prayed for guidance, and Isaac received Rebekah as God's choice. *Genesis 24:12-27, 62-67*

 - 4 Loved his wife.** Genesis says plainly that "he loved her," and she comforted him after Sarah's death. *Genesis 24:67*

 - 5 Prayed for his barren wife.** He "intreated the LORD for his wife," and the LORD answered. *Genesis 25:21*

 - 6 Buried his father with Ishmael.** The two half-brothers laid Abraham to rest together. *Genesis 25:9*

 - 7 Favored Esau.** He loved Esau "because he did eat of his venison," while Rebekah loved Jacob. *Genesis 25:28*

 - 8 Repeated his father's lie.** In Gerar he said Rebekah was his sister, until Abimelech saw them together. *Genesis 26:6-11*

 - 9 Reaped a hundredfold.** He sowed in a year of famine, "and the LORD blessed him." *Genesis 26:12-14*

 - 10 Chose peace over quarrels.** When herdsmen fought over his wells, he moved on until he found room at Rehoboth. *Genesis 26:15-22*

 - II Worshiped at Beersheba.** God appeared to him there. He built an altar and made a covenant of peace with Abimelech. *Genesis 26:23-31*

 - 12 Blessed both sons.** He blessed Jacob and Esau "concerning things to come." *Genesis 27:27-40; Hebrews 11:20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Isaac.

Old Testament

Genesis 21–35	The main account of his life
Genesis 17:19–21	God's covenant promised to Isaac before birth
Exodus 3:6	"The God of Isaac"
Genesis 31:42, 53	Jacob calls God "the fear of Isaac"
Psalms 105:8–10	The covenant sworn to Isaac

New Testament

Matthew 22:32	"Not the God of the dead, but of the living"
Romans 9:7–10	"In Isaac shall thy seed be called"
Galatians 4:28	"As Isaac was, are the children of promise"
Hebrews 11:17–20	Offered by faith; Isaac blessed his sons by faith
Echo: John 19:17	A beloved son carries the wood up a hill

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Isaac do each time the herdsmen quarreled over his wells (Genesis 26:17–22)?
2. *Understand:* Isaac repeated his father's faith and his mistakes. Why are family patterns so hard to break?
3. *Apply:* Isaac loved Esau more. Where might you be showing favoritism?
4. *Apply:* Isaac moved on until he found "room." Is there a quarrel you could step away from for peace?